

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 31 Summary

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This lesson focuses on **when** to use the present tense in Spanish, not just how to conjugate it. Conjugation guides (including regular and irregular verbs) are provided as a downloadable PDF in the classroom section. The goal of this lesson is to understand how the present tense functions in conversation and how its usage sometimes differs from English.

Standard Uses (Just Like English)

The Spanish present tense is used much like in English for the following:

1. Actions happening right now

Examples:

Quiero ir a la tienda. = I want to go to the store.

Tengo que ir a la tienda. = I have to go to the store.

¿Puedo ir a la tienda? = Can I go to the store?

2. Habitual actions

Examples:

María trabaja todos los sábados. = María works every Saturday.

Juan siempre llega tarde. = Juan always arrives late.

3. Near future (with time expressions)

Examples:

¿Trabajas mañana? = Do you work tomorrow?

No, trabajo el domingo. = No, I work on Sunday.

(Note: Use the article with days in Spanish – *el domingo*, *los sábados*, etc.)

Unique Uses in Spanish

Polite requests (present tense used like “would” or “could”)

Spanish often uses the plain present tense to make polite requests – something that sounds unnatural in English.

Examples:

¿Me haces un favor? = Would you do me a favor?

¿Me traes más servilletas? = Would you bring me more napkins?

¿Me pasas la sal? = Would you pass me the salt?

¿Me ayuda con esto? = Can you help me with this?

¿Me presta una pluma? = Will you lend me a pen?

Note: The verbs are in the tú or usted form, depending on the level of formality. Adding *por favor* softens the tone but is optional.

➡ Difference from Present Progressive

In English, we often use the present progressive (I am doing, I am waiting), but in Spanish the plain present tense is often preferred.

Examples:

¿Qué haces? = What are you doing?

¿Qué esperas? = What are you waiting for?

Although you can say:

¿Qué estás haciendo? or ¿Qué estás esperando?,

the shorter present tense forms are often more common, especially with familiar verbs.

In Spain, you may hear the added “a” in questions like ¿A qué esperas?

In Latin America, it's often just ¿Qué esperas?

➡ Verbs of Motion (Ir, Venir)

Stick with the **present tense** for verbs like *ir* (to go) and *venir* (to come), even when in English we might say “I am going” or “He is coming.”

Examples:

Voy a la tienda. = I’m going to the store.

Juan viene a la casa. = Juan is coming to the house.

These are often used in the present tense to express actions happening now or soon.

➡ Conjugation Tip

Conjugation practice is important, but focus on patterns. Learn the endings first, then plug in verbs.

For AR verbs (Latin America, without vosotros):

hablo, hablas, habla, hablamos, hablan

For ER and IR verbs:

como, comes, come, comemos, comen

viv[o/es/e/imos/en]

European Spanish learners need to include *vosotros* and note that the endings differ for -AR vs -ER/-IR.

If you already know your present tense conjugations, feel free to move to the next lesson. If not, download the PDF guide and practice until you feel comfortable. Remember, conjugation is repetition — usage is understanding.